

Literature without authorship: Variation and style in AI-generated fiction

Generative AI has shown that Large Language Models can generate literary fiction (Danesi, 2024). Fiction, however, is culturally and historically tied to the notion of authorship. Literary fiction presupposes originality, and originality presupposes variation: each work of literature is expected to be unique. If style depends on different sources (writers) making different choices, and AI texts all come from the same source (the same LLM), then AI cannot *have* style in the authorial sense. The emergence of AI as a producer of fictional texts therefore raises the question of the consequences for literary fiction when texts are generated without an authorial subject, and therefore without the main cultural mechanism that underwrites originality through variation. Understanding AI-generated fiction enables us to see what remains of literature when authorship is removed (Danesi, 2024). If meaning arises not from authorial intention (Barthes, 1977), then a text generated without an author is not an illegitimate text. The key issue is therefore not whether AI can generate texts that pass as literary texts, but whether fiction generated without authorship preserves the variability that underlies originality in literary production. To address this issue, a corpus of 1000 human-authored short stories was collected for 30 authors. For each human text, an AI text was generated by GPT. The corpus was analyzed using Lexical Multidimensional Analysis (Berber Sardinha & Fitzsimmons-Doolan, 2025), designed to identify sets of correlated lexical items that when interpreted reveal stylistic dimensions. The analysis was conducted by POS-tagging and lemmatizing the corpus, and entering the lemma counts in a factor analysis, which returned factors of correlated lexical items. This enabled us to measure the variation among human-authored texts and AI-generated texts. The dimensions and the comparisons between human and AI texts will be discussed in the presentation.

References

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